

Persona / User Profile

A composite archetype representing a user segment

PROFESSIONAL DEFINITION

A persona is a fictional but evidence-based character that represents a key user segment — with goals, behaviours, context, frustrations and a name and face. It gives an abstract 'user' a concrete identity teams can design for and refer to consistently.

WHO DEVELOPED IT

Introduced to software design by Alan Cooper in *The Inmates Are Running the Asylum* (1998); adopted broadly across UX and marketing.

WHY IT WAS DEVELOPED

Designing for 'everyone' produces products for no-one. Personas focus teams on specific, representative people and prevent designers from unconsciously designing for themselves.

HOW IT IS USED

From research, teams cluster users into segments and build a persona per segment, including goals and pain points, then test decisions against 'would this work for [persona]?'.

WHEN IT IS USED

After empathy research, to carry a shared user model through Define, Ideate and Test.

BY WHOM IT IS USED

UX, product and marketing teams.

FIGURE 1 · PROCESS VIEW

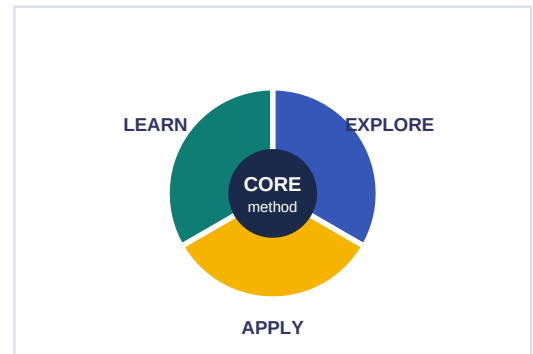


Figure 1. Persona / User Profile framed as a continuous, iterative method — explore, apply and learn cycle back through the work rather than run once.

INNOVATION RELATIVE TO PRIOR PRACTICE

It gives research a **memorable, shareable face**, aligning stakeholders on who they are building for far more durably than a data table.

RELATED FRAMEWORKS IN THIS COURSE

Empathy Map *Slibrary 5*

Customer Journey Map *Slibrary 5*

AEIOU *Slibrary 5*

SOURCES (HARVARD · CITE THEM RIGHT)

Cooper, A. (1999) *The Inmates Are Running the Asylum*. Indianapolis: Sams.

IDEO (2015) *The Field Guide to Human-Centered Design*. San Francisco: IDEO.org.